F O R E W O R D

It was with slight trepidation that I agreed to design Captain America for Joe Johnston and Marvel Studios. I'd worked with Joe before and enjoyed the collaboration with an imaginative, experienced director and superb artist who somehow knew how to make a tough job fun. Marvel Studios had a reputation for caring about the look of the films they made with their well-loved characters, so I was in good hands there. My problem?

It was that my father, a history professor of no small recognition in his field, happened to specialize in the American involvement in the Second World War and to have fought in it. Hewing this closely in a movie based on a comic book to a period and intense experience that in many ways was still very much alive for him gave me pause. I was acutely aware of the danger of trivializing or misrepresenting factual events for the dubious benefit of selling popcorn.

What kept occurring to me, though, was the image of Cap belting Hitler on a comic-book cover that was on the street even before the United States entered that war. Captain America was part of the history of that period, presented by his creators partly as a tool of persuasion intended to coax the United States off the sidelines of that war and shoulder the burden thrust upon it by unprecedented world events. At a time when Americans were emerging from the Depression to dream of a better future, they were presented with the more likely alternative of a bleak, totalitarian, soul-crushing world in which the bully gets away with stomping on the little guy. I read moral indignation behind the creation of the character, and America was founded on outrage against tyranny. While "wrapping oneself in the flag" has come to mean conservatism disguised as patriotism, I think that during this dire time of stark moral imperatives, Captain America's look was an appropriate call for national resolve and action. I decided in the end that my father of anyone would understand the value of using fictional narrative based on fact to examine the cause and effect of an historical event — that is, imaginatively nudging the "story" part of history to reveal truth.

There is an aspect of filmmaking that often reminds me of a military campaign (though not the actual letting of blood — yet!). You have to rally the troops and muster supplies, determine your objective and strategize its accomplishment, allocate your resources, navigate logistical quagmires, and mobilize to fight the battles and ultimately win the war. The First Avenger was no exception to this metaphor. I started designing the film in Los Angeles with my frequent collaborator and Supervising Art Director John Dexter and a fantastic L.A.-based art department. After a worldwide scout for locations, we settled on the United Kingdom — requiring a move to London and a new art department, where the exceptionally capable Chris Lowe joined John in supervising it. Many of the challenges seemed insurmountable — but our resourceful Gen. Johnston always seemed to have another, better idea. We did finally win our battles, and this book supplies evidence of the effort of the talented individuals who created the work that gives form, color and texture to the film.

Rick Heinrichs